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What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **A growing number** of commercial-real-estate buyers staring at rising interest rates are threatening to walk away from recent transactions unless sellers offer better terms. **A1**
- ◆ **The yield on 10-year U.S. Treasuries** touched a 24-year high, while the Nasdaq clinched a record with a rise of 1%. The S&P 500 and Dow advanced 0.7% and 0.2%, respectively. **B1**
- ◆ **A major Mattel** shareholder called for the toy maker to explore strategic alternatives as the company deals with a wobbly stock price and a chief-executive transition. **B3**
- ◆ **KKR entered an agreement** to buy Gen II, a fund administrator that targets buyout and other types of private-capital funds, in a transaction that values the business at roughly \$5 billion including debt. **B2**
- ◆ **Paramount Skydance** provided more details of its leadership structure, confirming the positions of David Ellison, Bari Weiss and Mark Thompson. **B3**
- ◆ **GE HealthCare** Technologies said that it planned to purchase a manufacturer of radioactive substances used in medical imaging for \$945 million in cash. **B3**
- ◆ **Saudi Aramco** Chief Executive Amin Nasser said that global oil inventories have been sharply depleted by the Middle East conflict and could take as long as two years to rebuild. **B11**
- ◆ **German robotics startup RobCo** sold shares in a deal that values the company at more than \$1 billion, double the level reached earlier this year. **B4**

Worldwide

- ◆ **Urgent concerns about** a potentially complex drone attack ordered by Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps drove the decision to remove a dozen B-1 bomber aircraft from a U.K. military base on Sunday. **A7**
- ◆ **Germany and France** proposed a new stratagem to repel a flood of cheap Chinese imports, setting the stage for a confrontation with Beijing. **A1**
- ◆ **Saudi and Yemeni** forces pressed a counteroffensive against Houthi fighters, seeking to oust the rebels from a strategic Red Sea port. **A7**
- ◆ **The president says** he will pay for pro-Trump television ads using funds from his super PAC rather than the federal government, after criticism that the spots might violate federal law. **A6**
- ◆ **Oil companies** seeking to avoid lawsuits over climate change faced questions at the Supreme Court and scrutiny of the industry's campaign to quash cases brought by state and local governments. **A2**
- ◆ **Three neuroscientists** were awarded the 2026 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine for their work on optogenetics, a method of controlling nerve cells with light, which makes it possible to study how the brain shapes memories, feelings and behaviors. **A3**
- ◆ **Russian authorities** are investigating the death of a woman who worked at a Siberian institute for infectious diseases and have placed her contacts under medical observation. **A7**
- ◆ **Book bans in public schools** in the past year numbered nearly 12,000, PEN America reported, the highest total ever recorded. **A4**
- ◆ **Died: Dennis Hastert**, 84, former House speaker. **A3**

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Housing Is Key Issue as Spain Sets Elections



MANURE COUNTEROFF/GETTY IMAGES

POLITICS OF PROTEST: As people protested in Barcelona against high rents, Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez on Monday called snap elections. He is hoping outrage on the issue will help his socialist party stave off a challenge from the right. **A8**

Germany and France Push EU To Get Tough on Chinese Trade

New proposal would create tool to level playing field; U.S. could be a target, too

By BERTRAND BENOIT AND KIM MACKRAEL

Germany and France are proposing a new weapon for Europe to fight back against a flood of cheap Chinese imports, setting the stage for a confrontation with Beijing.

The countries, ahead of a European Union leaders' summit next week, are proposing that the bloc lower its bar for

blocking Chinese products and allow the bloc to move faster on such actions. With this new power, the EU could potentially bar Beijing from one of its last major high-income markets in the world within days of the decision being taken.

The move is a high-stakes gambit ahead of a meeting between EU and Chinese trade officials this week aimed at strengthening Europe's hand in negotiations.

"We now have a broad European consensus on how to respond to China. This is extremely important as we head into the most consequential

few weeks in EU-China relations in years," said Noah Barkin, an analyst with Rhodium Group in Berlin. "The next few months will be extremely challenging. The EU can expect Beijing to retaliate if it presses ahead with new trade cases and new instruments."

Paris and Berlin have been at odds for months about how to protect European manufacturers from cheap Chinese imports because of Germany's traditional reluctance to interfere with free trade. Yet the competition has hit Germany, the EU's largest economy and its manufacturing heartland, particularly badly. Flagship

companies, including carmaker Volkswagen, have announced massive job cuts in recent months, changing minds in Berlin and paving the way for the Franco-German initiative, officials said.

The proposed tool would "allow for decisive and systemic reaction...and for powerful measures up to an immediate cutoff from the internal market if needed," French President Emmanuel Macron and German Chancellor Friedrich Merz wrote to the European Commission. It could be used if a trading partner deliberately under-

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To Calm AI Fears, Tech Firms Use Cuddly Mascots

By SUZANNE VRANICA

AI companies are trying a new charm offensive: using characters that look like cuddly stuffed animals to potentially make their technology feel a little less scary.

OpenAI's new AI agents are embodied by colorful characters with bow ties and glasses, while the mascot for Meta Platforms' Muse assistant is a rosy-cheeked, egg-shaped character. And Anthropic has its friendly pixelated orange crab, Clawd.

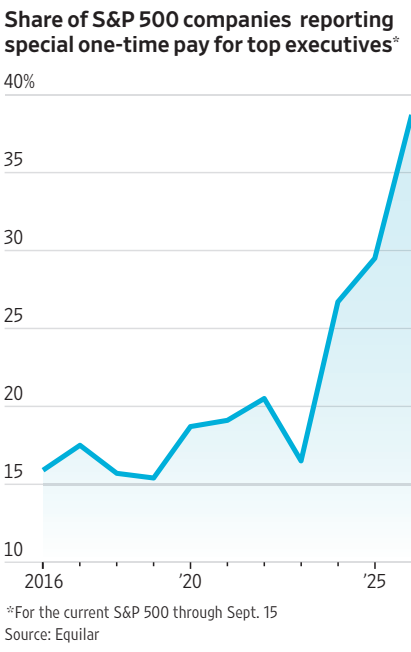
As public anxiety mounts over job losses and existential risks to humanity from AI, tech firms are taking a page from the marketing playbooks of consumer product companies and pharmaceutical firms by rolling out a series of adorable mascots.

The aim is to make the AI assistants now writing code, crawling the internet and booking appointments on our behalf a little more approachable, distinct and trustworthy. If the Jolly Green Giant could get kids to eat their vegetables, perhaps a sweet anthropomorphic triangle can win over AI skeptics.

"Fear of AI grows every day and it's hard to be scared of something cute," said branding consultant veteran Allen Adamson. "It's easier to trust

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◆ **Steps to take if AI agents handle your to-do list.... A11**



One-Off Bonuses Flow To CEOs

Special executive payouts, which not long ago were awarded only occasionally, are now surging, along with the amounts. Companies in the S&P 500 doled out \$1.7 billion in special awards last year, up 50% from a year earlier, a Wall Street Journal analysis found. **B1**

How F1 Drivers Beat Jet Lag: They All Live the Same Lie

Drivers live in a nocturnal bubble where everyone pretends they're still in Europe

By STU WOO

SINGAPORE—Every autumn, an elite group of 3,000 business travelers flies halfway around the world for a high-stakes event with millions of dollars on the line. To stay sharp, they've cracked the secret to beating jet lag.

They don't even try.

The group: the drivers, mechanics and entire entourage of auto racing's Formula One. For one week at the Singapore Grand Prix, they simply stay on Europe local time—which is morning back home—eat afternoon omelets and have dinner well af-

ter midnight.

The upside-down life ensures peak performance at 200 miles an hour during the race, which takes place Sunday night, and zero adjustment when they return to Europe.

"It's quite pleasant," said Nico Hülkenberg, a driver for Audi. "You don't have that much jet lag."

Humans have conquered long-distance aviation, but not the bodily shock of crossing time zones. The resulting brain fog has been blamed for diplomatic mishaps, Olympic disappointments and the recent downfall of the chief

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A race against time

Baseball for Kids Is Breaking the Bank

Travel teams, specialized training and high-end gear crank up the costs

By HARRIET RYAN

The second baseman stood 3-foot-6. The shortstop weighed 44 pounds.

At a club baseball tournament east of Los Angeles this summer, the 6-year-olds on teams from as far away as Arizona were too young to pitch the ball themselves, but their parents were spending thousands on baseball.

There were club dues, tournament fees, hotels, transportation, uniforms and equipment. An app offering "advanced statistics" and video of at-bats was \$191 a year. Even watching from the stands has a price—this tournament had a \$60-a-head pass for spectators. Spending

\$10,000 a year is common.

"Nowadays...in order to get certain opportunities, you have to pay money," said Carlos Avila, the national director of ZT Athletics, a private-equity backed company with three 6-and-under teams in the tournament. "People are trying to get ahead of the curve."

America's national pastime, played by generations of children up and down the economic spectrum, is increasingly a sport for rich kids.

Many adults remember Little League and rec programs, dad coaches and the snack shack. Youth baseball is now an intense and costly year-round endeavor dominated by

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INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL
What grip strength can tell you and your doctor about your health. **A10**



BUSINESS & FINANCE
Popular jewelry maker Mejuri got caught in a whirlwind when gold went haywire. **B1**